

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 999

By Roberts

A RESOLUTION to recognize Tennessee Supreme Court Justice Holly Kirby on the occasion of her retirement from the bench.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should honor those jurists who have performed with uncommon devotion and probity throughout their years on the bench; and

WHEREAS, Supreme Court Justice Holly Kirby is one such individual, who, after a distinguished judicial career, is taking her well-earned retirement after twelve years on the Tennessee Supreme Court; and

WHEREAS, a lifelong Tennessean, Justice Kirby was born in Memphis and graduated from high school in Columbia; she earned a Bachelor of Science degree in Mechanical Engineering with high honors from the University of Memphis in 1979 and a Juris Doctor degree from the University of Memphis School of Law in 1982, where she served on the Law Review editorial board; and

WHEREAS, upon her graduation from law school, Justice Holly Kirby served as judicial law clerk to the Honorable Harry W. Wellford of the United States Court of Appeals for the Sixth Circuit before entering private practice with the Memphis law firm of Burch, Porter & Johnson, where she specialized in employment litigation, served on the firm's management committee, and, in 1990, became the firm's first female partner; and

WHEREAS, from 1989 to 1994, Justice Kirby served as a member of the Tennessee Appellate Court Nominating Commission and as its chair in 1994, demonstrating an early commitment to the fair and effective administration of justice; and

WHEREAS, in 1995, at the age of thirty-eight, Justice Holly Kirby achieved a historic milestone when she became the first woman in Tennessee history to serve on the Tennessee Court of Appeals; and

WHEREAS, during her tenure on the Court of Appeals, Justice Kirby served the State's judicial ethics regulatory body, first as a member of an independent ethics panel and later as a member of the Board of Judicial Conduct, reflecting her steadfast commitment to judicial integrity; and

WHEREAS, in 2014, after nearly nineteen years of exemplary service on the intermediate appellate court, Justice Holly Kirby was appointed to the Tennessee Supreme Court by Governor Bill Haslam; and

WHEREAS, a career appellate jurist of remarkable productivity and insight, Justice Kirby has participated in many thousands of appellate decisions and has authored well over 1,000 opinions, and she has earned the confidence of the citizens of Tennessee through six successful statewide elections; and

WHEREAS, Justice Holly Kirby served as Chief Justice of the Tennessee Supreme Court from 2023 to September 2025, becoming the fourth woman in Tennessee history to hold that distinguished position; and

WHEREAS, as Chief Justice, she championed critical improvements to Tennessee's system of indigent representation, culminating in two consecutive years of increased funding totaling more than twenty-six million dollars and the establishment of a new and sustainable system to support that essential function; and

WHEREAS, during her tenure as Chief Justice, Justice Kirby also led efforts to address the increasing threats to members of the judiciary and court personnel, working to strengthen laws on intimidation of judicial officials, improve coordination with law enforcement, implement rapid-response reporting systems, and enhance protections for judges, their families, and judicial staff; and

WHEREAS, throughout her career, Justice Holly Kirby has been recognized with numerous honors and awards, including the Justice Frank F. Drowota III Award and the Tennessee Bar Association President's Award; she has also received the Marion Griffin-Frances Loring Award from the Memphis Association for Women Attorneys, the Distinguished

Leadership Award from Women in Numbers, and recognition as Community Mother of the Year by the Tennessee Justice Center; and

WHEREAS, her alma mater has repeatedly honored her achievements, naming her Outstanding Young Alumna in 1996, Outstanding Alumna of the College of Engineering in 2002, Special Distinguished Alumna of the Cecil C. Humphreys School of Law in 2016, and a Pillar of Excellence in 2025; Columbia Central High School likewise recognized her as an Outstanding Distinguished Alumna; and

WHEREAS, Justice Kirby is a Fellow of the Memphis and Shelby County Bar Foundation, the Tennessee Bar Foundation, and the American Bar Foundation and has been an active member of numerous professional organizations, including the Tennessee Bar Association, the Tennessee Lawyers' Association for Women, and the Memphis and Shelby County Bar Association; and

WHEREAS, throughout her estimable career, Justice Kirby has demonstrated the utmost professionalism, ability, and integrity, winning the respect and admiration of members of the bench and the bar alike; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Justice Holly Kirby for her distinguished service to the State of Tennessee and extend to her our best wishes for a happy and fulfilling retirement from the bench and every continued success in her future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.